“Again?” He huffed. “What’s wrong with her now?”

“Dr. Capek will send you a copy of his report.”

“Who will make up the quotas for you both?” He flung his arms up in frustration, but fortunately didn’t order them back to their workstations.

Since Rose began delivering the sick bay reports to the Gestapo office, Léa had noticed a change in the Meisters’ attitude toward the sisters. Though she felt uneasy about Rose’s deepening interaction with Reinhardt—Rose said he kept her in his office every night for half an hour, sometimes more, talking about Felix, his parents and German and Prussian history because that was the subject he’d studied in school before the war—she also valued the broader freedom it granted her.

Outside, Maria stopped on the street. Sunlight hit her shoulders as she doubled over, holding against another wave of pain. Léa rubbed her back. Coal smoke and street dust swirled in the air. She could feel the throbbing in Maria’s body. The short intervals between contractions alarmed her because she didn’t want her to have this baby anywhere but in the sick bay.

After the pain subsided and Maria stood upright, they continued walking, Léa counted the seconds until the next contraction hit.

“Come on, just a little farther,” she said, encouraging her.

Léa helped her up the stairs into the sick bay. Maria’s eyes widened, and Léa understood the pain was escalating fast. She guided Maria onto the bed while Josef washed his hands before coming over to examine her.

“The contractions are seventy seconds apart,” Léa said. “I timed them on our way here.”

He nodded and examined her. “She’s fully dilated.” He turned to Léa. “You were right to get her here so quickly.”

She was spending more time at the sick bay, taking on an increasingly supportive role. Josef had too much to do—in addition to typing reports for the Gestapo, he kept an inventory of the medical supplies, tracked financial accounts and disinfected all items used during the day to prevent the spread of disease. This was all on top of his day job of looking after the patients. Léa had seen that he needed help, and once she was proficient with the German keyboard and could finish the patient reports in no time, she began to disinfect the medical equipment by soaking them in chlorine tablets mixed with water.

“Maria, I need you to push,” Josef said, gently.